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# Sonoma State president placed on leave over Palestine divestment

May 16, 2024 | AsAmNews (USA)
Author: Randall | Section: Asian Americans | 420 Words
OpenURL Link

California State University's chancellor placed the president of Sonoma State on administrative leave Wednesday after he agreed to demands from pro-Palestinian protesters.

Chancellor Mildred Garcia made the decision, accusing Mike Lee of "insubordination" and acting without "appropriate approvals," the Press Democrat reported.

"On Tuesday evening, Sonoma State University President Mike Lee sent a campuswide message concerning an agreement with campus protesters. That message was sent without the appropriate approvals ... because of this insubordination and consequences it has brought upon the system, President Lee has been placed on administrative leave," Garcia's statement read.

Lee accepted the decision and acknowledged the "unintended consequences" of his actions.

"In my attempt to find agreement with one group of students, I marginalized other members of our student population and community. I realize the harm that this has caused, and I take full ownership of it. I deeply regret the unintended consequences of my actions," he said to the campus community in a follow up email, according to Politico.

On Tuesday, Lee sent out a campus wide email announcing the university would begin "divestment strategies that include seeking ethical alternatives" and would no longer participate in study abroad program and faculty exchanges with Israel.

The Los Angeles Times reports Lee's letter to the campus community Tuesday went further than any other university. Universities such as UC Berkeley and UC Riverside had stated it would divest from weapons companies, but none specifically mentioned Israel.

Lee's announcement on Tuesday has been met with criticism from some state legislators.

State Senator Scott Weiner (D-SF) and Assemblymember Jesse Gabriel (D-Encino) supported Garcia's decision saying Lee's agreement with the pro-Palestinian protesters to support an academic boycott of Israel "was totally unacceptable and evidence that former President Lee is unfit to lead one of our great state institutions. We look forward to working with Chancellor García and the CSU Trustees to pursue a different path that will promote learning, respectful dialogue, mutual respect, inclusivity, and peace," the Times reported.

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- **Citation (apa Style)**
  Randall. (2024, May 16). Sonoma State president placed on leave over Palestine divestment.*AsAmNews (USA)*. Available from NewsBank: Access World News – Historical and Current: https://infoweb.newsbank.com/apps/news/document-view?

p=WORLDNEWS&docref=news/1991A4DA689AA358.